Vakreshvara Pandita

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A Dear Companion of Chaitanya

When Vrindavana Dasa Thakura reaches the story of Vakreshvara Pandita in the "Chaitanya-bhagavata," he first of all glorifies the man himself:

"Vakreshvara Pandita was a very dear companion of Lord Chaitanya. Simply remembering him can purify the whole universe. He was constantly absorbed in ecstatic feelings of separation from Krishna. When he danced, even the gods and demons were struck with wonder." (CB, Antya 3.469–470)

So the Vaishnavas have remembered him: a man in whom love for Krishna lived without pause, and a dancer whose dance amazed the denizens of heaven.

Krishnadasa Kaviraja Gosvami, describing the tree of Sri Chaitanya, calls him its fifth branch:

"The fifth branch is Vakreshvara Pandita, the beloved servant of Sri Chaitanya. Overwhelmed by unbroken bliss, he could dance for three days and nights." (CC, Adi 10.17)[1]

His name is woven into the very praise of the Lord: at the opening of the Madhya-khanda Vrindavana Dasa exclaims: "Glory to Him who is dear to the heart of Vakreshvara and Kashishvara!" (CB, Madhya 1.6)[2]

Appearance and Navadvipa

Vakreshvara Pandita appeared in this world on the krishna-panchami of the month of Ashadha. In our calendar this is the krishna-panchami of the month of Vamana — the Appearance Day of Srila Vakreshvara Pandita.

Nothing is known of his parents or family. His birthplace is said to be Guptipara near Triveni[3]. Before settling in Puri he lived in Sridham Navadvipa and was a companion of the Lord already in the days of His Navadvipa pastimes, and afterwards at His sannyasa and in Puri. He was a superb singer and dancer, and when Mahaprabhu began the sankirtana, Vakreshvara became one of its foremost singers and dancers.

The Dancer of the Sankirtana

Vakreshvara's dancing passed into legend. Once — in the house of Srivasa, it is said — he danced without a break for twenty-four praharas, that is, three days and nights: not by bodily strength, but in the unbroken bliss of love for Krishna. Krishnadasa Kaviraja also tells how the Lord Himself sang while he danced:

"Once Sri Chaitanya Himself was singing, and Vakreshvara Pandita, dancing before Him, fell at Mahaprabhu's feet and said: 'O moon-faced One! Give me ten thousand gandharvas. Let them sing and I will dance, and that will give me the greatest happiness.' Sri Chaitanya replied: 'You are like one of My wings; if I had another, I could fly through the sky.'" (CC, Adi 10.18–20)

In Navadvipa he danced in ecstasy at the kirtanas in the houses of Srivasa and Chandrashekhara. Vrindavana Dasa names him among those who came to the night kirtanas at Srivasa's: "…Shridhara, Sadashiva, Vakreshvara, Shrigarbha, Shuklambara…" (CB, Madhya 8.115). In the dramas the Lord staged in Srivasa's house he was one of the principal dancers, and a song signed by Vrindavana Dasa names among those who danced in the Lord's kirtana Ramai, Raghunandana, Srivasa, Haridasa, Vakreshvara, Dvija Haridasa and Shankara[4]. More about these kirtanas is told in the article on Srivasa

Pandita.

He was at the Lord's side in the great events of the Navadvipa pastimes. When Jagai and Madhai were brought into the Lord's house and the doors were shut, Vakreshvara was among the few closest companions who saw the brothers receive mercy. Vrindavana Dasa names him among those who knew the Lord's pastimes: “Pundarika Vidyanidhi, Haridasa Thakura, Garuda, Ramai, Srinivasa, Gangadasa, Vakreshvara Pandita and Chandrashekhara Acharya were thoroughly acquainted with the pastimes of Lord Chaitanya” (CB, Madhya 13.239–240).

On the day the Lord led the nagara-kirtana to the Kazi's house, the procession moved in three parties: Haridasa in front, Advaita in the middle, and Gaurachandra Himself at the rear, with Gadadhara, Vakreshvara, Murari, Srivasa and Gopinatha walking beside Him. Among those who danced that day Vrindavana Dasa names him too:

“Among them were such great devotees as Murari, Mukunda Datta, Ramai, Govinda, Vakreshvara and Vasudeva.” (CB, Madhya 23.209)

He also witnessed the Lord's mercy to the poor trader Shridhara. According to Lochana Dasa's “Chaitanya-mangala,” after the Lord's sannyasa Nityananda went after Him together with Chandrashekhara, Damodara, Vakreshvara and others.

Mercy to Devananda

The best-known story about Vakreshvara is how he saved Devananda Pandita.

Devananda of Kuliya was a great scholar and ascetic. He had mastered his senses, believed in God and read nothing but the “Bhagavatam,” yet he expounded it in a monistic way, longing for liberation. Once Srivasa came to his reading, and the words of the “Bhagavatam” filled him with such love for Krishna that he wept. Devananda's disciples, who could not tell prema from ordinary sentiment, pushed him out, and Devananda did not stop them. Many days later the Lord, hearing how he expounded the “Bhagavata,” angrily and sternly rebuked a man who did not honour the Vaishnavas. Nor did Devananda at that time have faith in Mahaprabhu. According to one account, the Lord, on learning of the offence, spoke of the two Bhagavatas — the book and the devotee — and did not grant Devananda love of God. This story is told more fully in the article on Srivasa Pandita.

After the Lord's sannyasa it was Devananda's good fortune to meet Vakreshvara (CB, Antya 3.468). One day Vakreshvara came unexpectedly to his house of his own accord and began to sing and dance there. He did so out of causeless mercy — to show everyone by a living example why a Vaishnava is called Patita-pavana, “the purifier of the fallen”[5].

Devananda saw shining in him the power of a Vaishnava and a devotion to Vishnu unequalled in the three worlds, and his heart melted. He began to serve Vakreshvara with sincere love. While Vakreshvara danced, Devananda walked round him with a cane in his hand and held the crowd back; when Vakreshvara fell to the ground in ecstasy, Devananda laid his head in his lap, carefully gathered the dust from his body and smeared it on himself[6]. It is said that the crowd kept growing and clamouring while Vakreshvara sang and danced for another six hours into the night; when at last he sat down to rest, Devananda fell at his feet, and Vakreshvara blessed him: “May you have love for God.” From that day devotion grew in Devananda, and from that same day he began to serve the Vaishnavas.

His association with Vakreshvara removed all of Devananda's offences. From Vakreshvara's lips he heard the glory of Mahaprabhu and understood who He truly is, and faith in the Lord and a longing to see Gaurasundara awoke in him. Srila Bhaktisiddhanta Sarasvati remarks in his “Gaudiya-bhashya” that Devananda was a smarta, yet a scholar and an ascetic, who read the “Bhagavatam” alone; he lacked only

faith in Mahaprabhu, and this fault was corrected by Vakreshvara's mercy. The fruit of serving a Vaishnava is faith in the Lord's feet.

Devananda came to the Lord and begged forgiveness, and Gaurasundara forgave him everything. This happened when, five years after His sannyasa, the Lord came from Puri to Kuliya to see His mother and the Ganga, at the place now called Aparadha-bhanjana, “the destruction of offences”; the temple of Srila Sridhara Maharaja stands there today. Vrindavana Dasa records the Lord's words:

“The Lord said: ‘You served Vakreshvara Pandita, and that has brought you close to Me. Vakreshvara Pandita is filled with the spiritual energies of the Supreme Lord. Whoever serves him attains Krishna. Krishna has manifested His own abode in Vakreshvara's heart. When he dances, Krishna dances too. Wherever Vakreshvara stays, that place becomes like all the holy places together; Vaikuntha is manifest there.’” (CB, Antya 3.493–496)

Seeing the mercy Vakreshvara had shown Devananda, the Lord told him to expound the “Bhagavatam” in the spirit of bhakti. Krishnadasa Kaviraja sums it up:

“The fortieth branch, Devananda Pandita, was a reciter of the ‘Srimad-Bhagavatam.’ But by the mercy of Vakreshvara Pandita and by the special mercy of Sri Chaitanya he understood that the true essence of the Bhagavatam is bhakti.” (CC, Adi 10.77)

The heart of this story is plain. An offence against a Vaishnava is healed by the same tongue that gave it — by confessing the fault and glorifying Krishna and His devotees; serving a Vaishnava brings a faith in the Lord that a thousand atonements cannot give. The meaning of the “Bhagavata” opens not to a proud scholar but to one who has surrendered, for “Bhagavata” is at once the book, the devotee, and what the book teaches — pure bhakti. The book-Bhagavata and the devotee-Bhagavata are one, and whoever is blessed by a devotee soon attains love for Krishna.

In Puri

When the Lord took sannyasa and settled in Puri, Vakreshvara left Navadvipa to follow Him: he wished to dance in His sankirtana every day and to serve Him in His final pastimes. So he settled in Nilachala for good and became one of the Lord's constant companions. Krishnadasa Kaviraja names him together with those who were Mahaprabhu's very life:

“Among all the devotees who were intimate with the Lord in Jagannatha Puri, two — Paramananda Puri and Svarupa Damodara — were Sri Chaitanya's very life and breath. There were also Gadadhara, Jagadananda, Shankara, Vakreshvara, Damodara Pandita, Haridasa Thakura, Vaidya Raghunatha and Raghunatha Dasa. […] All these exalted devotees had accompanied the Lord everywhere before. When Sri Chaitanya settled in Jagannatha Puri, they stayed to serve Him there.” (CC, Adi 10.124–127)

And elsewhere, telling how Gadadhara Pandita settled in Nilachala (one biography calls this his kshetra-sannyasa — the vow never to leave the Kshetra):

“Gadadhara Pandita, Vakreshvara, Damodara, Shankara and Haridasa Thakura stayed to live with the Lord in Puri. Jagadananda, Bhagavan, Govinda, Kashishvara, Paramananda Puri and Svarupa Damodara also moved there.” (CC, Madhya 1.252–253)

Kavi Karnapura in the “Chaitanya-charita-mahakavya” mentions “Vakreshvara the dancer” coming to the Lord in Puri together with Vasudeva Datta and Bhagavan Acharya. In Nilachala Vakreshvara would sometimes invite the Lord to his home for a meal. Together with the Lord, Advaita and others he went to the garden of Tota-Gopinatha to hear Gadadhara Pandita read the “Bhagavatam.”

Yet here too his chief service remained his dance. At the evening kirtana in Nilachala the Lord divided the devotees into four parties:

“In one party Sri Nityananda danced, and in another Advaita Acharya. In the third party Vakreshvara Pandita danced, and in the fourth Srivasa Thakura. Mahaprabhu remained in the centre of the kirtana watching them all, and He also displayed one of His divine perfections. All the devotees singing and dancing on every side were convinced that Sri Chaitanya was looking at them alone.” (CC, Madhya 11.227–230)

At the Ratha-yatra the Lord told Nityananda, Advaita, Haridasa and Vakreshvara each to dance in his own party. Vakreshvara was the dancer of the fourth party:

“The Lord formed the fourth party headed by the kirtaniya Govinda Ghosha. The younger Haridasa, Vishnudasa and Raghava were to sing the response with him, and also the two brothers Madhava and Vasudeva Ghosha. Vakreshvara Pandita was chosen as the dancer.” (CC, Madhya 13.42–43)

The Ghosha brothers led the singing, and “Vakreshvara himself” danced before them[7].

When the Lord circled the temple of Jagannatha with a great kirtana of seven parties, each had its own chief dancer, and one of them was again Vakreshvara (CC, Antya 10.58–61). During the festival at Gundicha, where kirtana went on morning, noon and evening, the Lord made now Advaita, now Nityananda, now Haridasa, Achyutananda or Vakreshvara dance (CC, Madhya 14.70–72). At times the Lord told Vakreshvara to dance and Himself became the singer:

“Then the Lord told Vakreshvara to dance, and He Himself began to sing. Many fine singers such as Svarupa Damodara began to sing with the Lord and, in a trance of divine love, forgot time and place.” (CC, Madhya 14.100–101)

In the water pastimes in Lake Indradyumna, when the devotees paired off, his opponent was Raghava Pandita:

“Srivasa Thakura joined in a water battle with Gadadhara Pandita, and Raghava Pandita with Vakreshvara.” (CC, Madhya 14.81)

When Haridasa Thakura wished to leave his body before the Lord's eyes, Mahaprabhu came to his courtyard and held a great sankirtana, and its chief dancer was Vakreshvara. Svarupa sang, Vakreshvara danced around Haridasa's body, and when Gaurasundara with kirtana laid that body in samadhi on the shore of the ocean, he danced again.

When the Lord set out from Nilachala for Vrindavana, Vakreshvara was among His companions. At Ramakeli he saw the Lord grant His mercy to Rupa and Sanatana; at the Lord's bidding the brothers touched the feet of His companions, and they blessed them. He also greeted the Lord on the bank of Narendra-sarovara when He returned from Vrindavana (CC, Madhya 25.219–221).

To Vallabha Bhatta the Lord said that He had “come to know” love for Krishna through the devotees of Bengal, the preachers of the holy name:

“Acharyaratna, Acharyanidhi, Gadadhara Pandita, Jagadananda, Damodara, Shankara, Vakreshvara, Kashishvara, Mukunda, Vasudeva, Murari and many other Vaishnavas were born in the land of Bengal. Everywhere they preach the glory of chanting the holy names of God and the enchanting beauty of love for Krishna. Through them all I have understood the essence of pure devotion to Krishna.” (CC, Antya 7.48–50)

In Puri the Lord lived in the house of Kashi Mishra, the royal priest of King Prataparudra. It is said that this place later came to Vakreshvara, and that in the time of his disciple Gopala Guru the Deity of Sri Radhakanta was installed there[8].

After the Lord's Disappearance

Vakreshvara outlived the disappearance of Mahaprabhu and remained in Puri. When Srinivasa came there, he found Vakreshvara among the companions who, in separation from Gaura, had forgotten food and sleep and were always singing of His name, form, qualities and pastimes; from them Srinivasa received blessings ("Bhakti-ratnakara," 3).

The poem "Sri Gaura-krishnodaya" says that Vakreshvara was regarded as the Lord's first disciple and was placed in the very abode where the Lord had lived ("Gaura-krishnodaya," 18.60)[9]. The same poem names him first among the companions of His sankirtana (5.30).

The Outer Path of Worship in Rasa

Mahaprabhu entrusted Svarupa Damodara with preaching the worship of Krishna in rasa. As Srila Bhaktivinoda Thakura writes in "Jaiva-dharma" (ch. 39), Svarupa set it down in his diary, his kadacha, in two parts. The inner path of rasopasana he placed in the mouth of Raghunatha Dasa, and Krishnadasa Kaviraja revealed it in the "Chaitanya-charitamrita" and the "Govinda-lilamrita." The outer path Svarupa handed to Vakreshvara. Thus the method of worship in madhura-rasa that comes from Svarupa spread along two lines: through Raghunatha Dasa and Krishnadasa Kaviraja — and through Vakreshvara and his disciple Gopala Guru Gosvami, who passed this treasure on along the chain of disciples.

Gopala Guru, formerly Makaradhvaja Pandita, was a brahmana of Utkala who from early childhood lived with Vakreshvara under his care. He became his beloved and chief disciple; his devotion to his guru was beyond description, and Vakreshvara was always pleased with him. On Vakreshvara's instruction Gopala Guru revealed the Gaura-mantra and the order of worship of Gaura. In "Jaiva-dharma" (ch. 26) Bhaktivinoda Thakura portrays Gopala Guru seated in Mahaprabhu's place in the house of Kashi Mishra, with Svarupa's teaching living on his lips.

Gopala Guru's disciple Dhyanachandra Gosvami continued his work. Gopala Guru's "Smarana-krama-paddhati" ("Seva-smarana-paddhati") and the "Dhyanachandra-paddhati" are well known among pure Gaudiya Vaishnavas. They record methods of bhajana and of worship with mantras, and for that reason they are not spread widely; worship in the Gaudiya sampradaya follows Dhyanachandra's "Paddhati." Gopala Guru also wrote the "Gaura-govindarchana-paddhati." The line of succession of the Radhakanta Matha, its "Guru-pranali," begins thus: Mahaprabhu, Vakreshvara, Gopala Guru, Dhyanachandra…

According to the "Vakreshvara-charita," five branches came from Vakreshvara: from Chandrashekhara, Shankararanya Acharya, Govindanada, Devananda and Gopala Guru. Many in Orissa have received initiation in his line and call themselves Gaudiya Vaishnavas. According to the "Anuragavalli," a record of the succession from Mahaprabhu was found with a descendant of Gopala Guru's family, and the "Nityananda-vamsha-vistara" says that at Prabhu's bidding Vakreshvara gave the mantra of Radha-Krishna to King Chakradeva[10]. Srila Jiva Gosvami in his vandana remembers the Lord immersed in the bliss of kirtana beside Vakreshvara.

Gopala Guru called his guru Tungavidya and the Son of Shachi Nanda-nandana, yet he taught nothing contrary to siddhanta: the teaching of Svarupa and Rupa stood firm on his lips, and there is nothing in him like the later gaura-nagari doctrine that grew up in Shrikhanda.

Govinda Deva and the "Gaura-krishnodaya"

The Utkala poet Sri Govinda Deva belonged to Vakreshvara's circle. In the year 1680 of the Shaka era (1758) he wrote the "Sri Gaura-krishnodaya," a poem in eighteen sargas on the pastimes of Gaura, in which he also describes the life of Vakreshvara; it was published by Srila Bhaktisiddhanta Sarasvati[11].

At the opening of the poem (1.5) the poet glorifies Rupa, Vakreshvara and other gurus but does not name Gopala Guru: perhaps he was not of his branch.

Departure

Vakreshvara Pandita left this world on the shukla-shashthi of the month of Ashadha[12]. Where this happened and where his samadhi is, the biographies do not say.

Aniruddha and Tungavidya

Who Vakreshvara is in the eternal pastimes is told by Kavi Karnapura in the "Gaura-ganoddesha-dipika":

"The fourth vyuha, Aniruddha, is Vakreshvara Pandita, who gave joy to the Lord by his dancing, born of absorption in Krishna. It was he who spoke sweet words to the feet of Chaitanya: 'O merciful One, give me a thousand singers.' By a distinction of her own manifestation, Shashirekha entered into him." (GGD 71–73)

Thus in Gaura-lila he is Aniruddha, the fourth of the chatur-vyuha, and one biography says that Kavi Karnapura thereby established him as vishnu-tattva; and Shashirekha[13], a friend of Radha, entered into him[14].

In the line of Gopala Guru he is honoured differently — as Tungavidya, one of the dear sakhis, a gopi skilled in song and dance. Dhyanachandra Gosvami in his "Paddhati" praises him as the best of brahmanas, a devotee of Chaitanya, always absorbed in preaching the sweet rasa of Radha and Krishna; his lips are adorned with songs given him by Gaura; from the joy of confidential service in Vrindavana the sattvika-bhavas — stupor and the rest — appear in him; he is the original dancer-avatara in Gaurasundara's absorption in the rasa of separation. Tungavidya lives eternally in Vraja in great elation and, like a heroine disappointed in awaiting her tryst (a vipralabdha), is ever filled with love for Krishna; in the age of Kali, in Gaura-rasa, the same person became famous once more as Vakreshvara[15].

Gopala Guru in the "Seva-smarana-paddhati" likewise honours his guru as Tungavidya Sakhi: "I worship Vakreshvara Pandita — Sri Tungavidya; I worship Sri Chaitanya, the son of Shachi — Nanda-nandana," and says that in the age of Kali she became famous as Vakreshvara. The "Guru-pranali" of the Radhakanta Matha adds: Vakreshvara, by nature an embodiment of rasa, in his perfected form is Tungavidya (Tunga). She has eight sakhis — Manjumedha, Sumadhura, Sumadhya, Madhurekshana, Tanumadhya, Madhusudha, Gunachuda and Varangana — and Gopala Guru is her maidservant Manjumedhika.

Telling of Vakreshvara on the day of his appearance, Vaishnavas remember his name, form, qualities, companions and pastimes, following the rupanuga sadhus — and hope thereby to be purified. For, in the words of Vrindavana Dasa, simply remembering him purifies the universe.

1. According to one biography, he is counted sometimes among the branches of Chaitanya and sometimes among those of Gadadhara Pandita.

2. One biography glorifies Vakreshvara with the verse "Glory to the wealth of Vakreshvara Pandita," citing CB, Madhya 7.3; but in our text of the "Chaitanya-bhagavata" that verse speaks of Jagadananda, Shrigarbha and Pundarika. A verse close in sense is CB, Madhya 1.6, quoted above.

3. Only one biography reports this; the others say nothing of his birthplace.

4. One biography cites this song as a passage of the "Chaitanya-bhagavata"; these lines are not in our text of the CB.

5. According to another account, Vakreshvara stayed with Devananda "by the will of providence"; so too the "Chaitanya-bhagavata": by the will of providence Devananda's devotion attracted him, and he stayed for a while in his ashrama (CB, Antya 3.474). According to a third account, he was singing and dancing one evening in the house of a certain devotee in Kuliya, and Devananda came there on hearing of the kirtana.

6. According to one account, Devananda stood before him spellbound for a long time, and wiped the dust from his body with his own shawl.

7. According to another account, there were four sampradayas at the Ratha-yatra, and among them Vakreshvara supposedly “founded a new sampradaya — of dance.” This is probably an inaccuracy: according to the “Chaitanya-charitamrita,” he was the dancer in Govinda Ghosha's party.

8. This is told in different ways. Some say that the Radhakanta Matha was founded by Gopala Guru himself. According to one biography, Vakreshvara lived in Kashi Mishra's house and himself installed the Deities of Radha-Kanta; according to another passage of the same book, Gopala Guru stayed there after Vakreshvara's departure and installed Radhakanta. According to a third biography, the Lord Himself entrusted the service of Radhakanta to Gopala Guru, while Vakreshvara never sat on the gadi of the Radhakanta Matha and was never its acharya, remaining in kirtana and dance with the Lord.

9. The sense of the verse is that Vakreshvara was deemed the Lord's first disciple and placed in that abode. It seems to refer to the time after the Lord's disappearance, when His companions placed Vakreshvara in His abode; by one interpretation, the Lord Himself so arranged it at His departure.

10. This report is chronologically doubtful.

11. According to one biography, the poem was written in Oriya “in the 17th year of the Gaura era”; this is probably an error of translation.

12. This date is given by two biographies (one of them following the “Dhyanachandra-paddhati”); the third gives no date of departure. Our calendar does not mark this day.

13. The “Gaura-ganoddesha-dipika” also names Kashishvara Gosvami as Shashirekha in Vraja: “Sri Kashishvara Gosvami is the former Shashirekha in Vraja” (GGD 166). Into Vakreshvara, according to verse 73, she entered “by a distinction of her own manifestation.”

14. One biography omits verse 72 and gives only verses 71 and 73. In the “Chaitanya-charitamrita” Vakreshvara asks not for a thousand singers but for ten thousand gandharvas (CC, Adi 10.19).

15. In the “Gaura-ganoddesha-dipika” (GGD 163) — and, following it, in two biographies — Prabodhananda Sarasvati is named as Tungavidya. These identifications differ, and we do not merge them.